

0 A.D.

THE STRATEGIST'S FIELD MANUAL

AN EIGHT-VOLUME BRUTALIST COMPENDIUM ·
PTOLEMIES AS WORKED EXAMPLE

VOL.00	ARMY COUNTER GUIDE
VOL.01	PTOLEMIES PLAYBOOK
VOL.02	ATTACK STRATEGIES
VOL.03	DEFENSE STRATEGIES
VOL.04	SCOUTING
VOL.05	ECONOMY + UPGRADES
VOL.06	MAP READING
VOL.07	BASE LAYOUT + BUILDINGS

ARMY / COUNTERS

ROCK · PAPER ·
SCISSORS

SPEARS STOP
HORSES

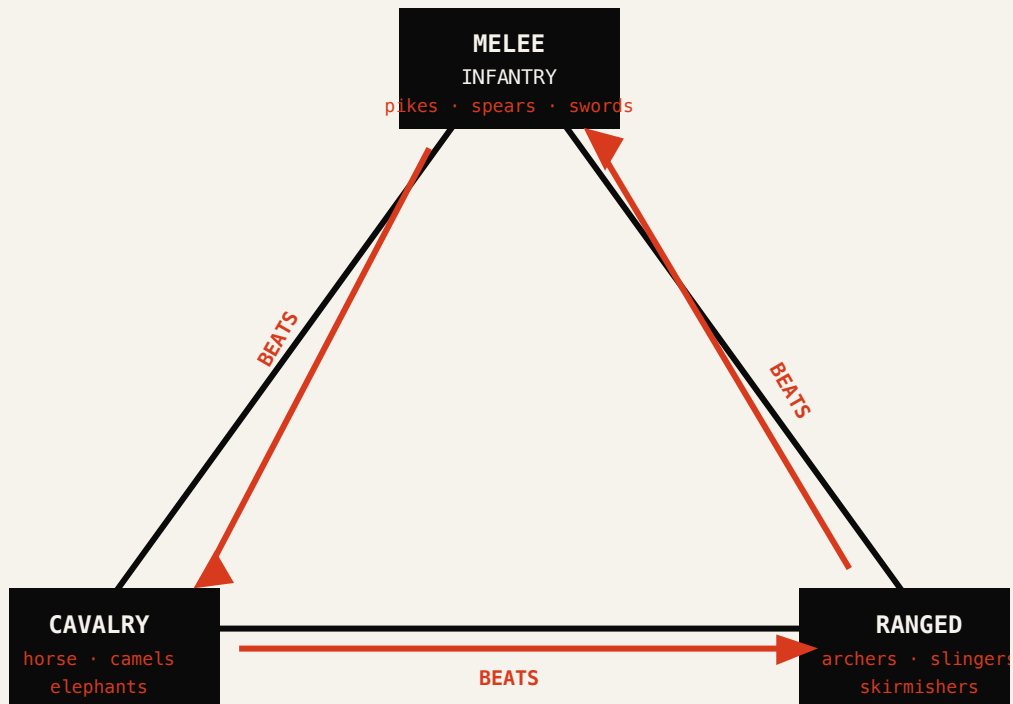
HORSES KILL
ARCHERS

READ BEFORE PLAY

CORE THE COUNTER TRIANGLE

| MEMORIZE THIS

Every army boils down to three roles. Each beats one, loses to one.



Mental shortcut: Spears stop horses. Horses run down archers. Archers shred spears. **That's the whole game.**

**WORKER**

/ eco

**SPEARMAN**

/ anti-cav

**ARCHER**

/ ranged DPS

**CAVALRY**/ scout +
raid**SIEGE**/ anti-
building

UNIT	ROLE	STRONG VS	WEAK VS
Spearman	Cheap anti-cav	Cavalry, Elephants	Archers, Swordsmen
Pikeman	Elite frontline	Cavalry (huge bonus)	Swordsmen, Ranged, Siege
Swordsman	Heavy melee DPS	Spearmen, Pikemen, Buildings	Cavalry, Skirmishers (kited)
Archer	Mass ranged DPS	Melee infantry	Cavalry charges
Skirmisher	Mobile harasser	Swordsmen, Slow melee	Archers (outranged), Cavalry
Slinger	Anti-building / anti-ranged	Buildings, other Ranged	Cavalry, Melee close-up
Cav (Spear)	Anti-cav harasser	Other Cavalry, Ranged	Pikemen, Spearmen
Cav (Sword)	Raid & flank	Ranged, Workers, Skirmishers	Pikemen, Spearmen
Cav (Javelin)	Hit-and-run	Workers, isolated units	Mass Archers, Pikemen
War Elephant	Tank / building crusher	Melee blobs, Buildings	Pikemen, Mass Ranged, Fire
Champion	Elite anything	Their counter-type's citizen units	Their own role's counter, cost
Siege	Anti-building	Walls, Towers, Buildings	EVERYTHING ELSE – esp. Cav

Cavalry is not your main combat unit. It's a tool. Use it for specific jobs.

// JOB 01 – SCOUTING

Find their base, expansions, idle armies. Always have 1-2 horses on patrol. **Replace instantly if killed.**

// JOB 02 – RAID WORKERS

Fastest unit, picks off villagers far from base. The single biggest source of "*why am I losing*" if you don't do this.

// JOB 03 – SNIPE SIEGE

Their ram rolls up. Your cav charges from behind. Siege has zero melee defense. **Free kill.**

// JOB 04 – FLANK RANGED

Ride around the pike wall and crash into the archer line behind it. Kills the DPS, the pikes become harmless.

NEVER: charge cav into pikes. You will lose 80% of them in 5 seconds.

I SEE X – WHAT DO I DO?

// SEE: CAVALRY APPROACHING BASE

1. **Garrison workers immediately** – houses, towers, CC. One hotkey saves your eco.
2. **Train spearmen / pikemen NOW.** Even 5–6 spears in a clump scares cav off.
3. **Pull them under a tower.** Towers + spears = cav graveyard.
4. **Don't chase.** Cav is faster. They'll kite back and re-raid elsewhere.

// SEE: WAVE OF ARCHERS / SKIRMISHERS

1. **Send cavalry around the flank** – never engage ranged from the front, they kite.
2. No cav? **Charge with swordsmen** through them; ranged melts in melee.
3. **Don't fight with spearmen** head-on – archers eat spears alive.
4. **Towers help.** Ranged has to stop to shoot, towers out-DPS them.

// SEE: PIKEMAN BLOCK / PHALANX PUSHING IN

1. **Don't melee them.** Pikes hit first and hard.
2. **Slingers + skirmishers** at range – pikes are slow, kite them while you shoot.
3. **Swordsmen or elephants** for a head-on break if you must.
4. **Look for siege behind the pikes** – that's the real threat. Pikes are bodyguard.

// SEE: SIEGE (RAMS, HELEPOLIS, TOWERS)

1. **Cavalry charge – NOW.** Siege has no melee defense. Your cav deletes it.
2. If already at wall, sally out a small squad from a gate. Don't let it work.
3. **Garrison the wall section** being attacked – archers inside towers shoot back.
4. After siege dies, **retreat.** Don't get drawn into the full engagement.

// SEE: WAR ELEPHANTS LUMBERING AT YOU

1. **Pikemen, lots of them.** Pikes have huge bonus damage vs elephants.
2. **Mass ranged from distance** – slingers especially.
3. **Don't bunch up.** Elephants do splash/trample damage. Spread out.
4. **Towers do bonus damage** to elephants. Use them.

// SEE: MIXED ARMY (THE REALISTIC CASE)

Real armies are combined arms: pikes front, archers back, cav on wings, siege in rear. You can't counter all of it. **Pick a role to win:**

- **Kill the siege first** if your walls are at stake
- **Flank the archers** with cav – kills the DPS, pikes become harmless
- **Retreat into kill zone** (towers + chokes) and attrition them

Fundamental defense move: let them attack into your towers + walls + garrisoned ranged. You win the trade just by existing there.

// Spears stop horses. Pikes stop them harder.

// Cavalry kills anything that can't kill it back fast.

// Ranged beats melee – unless melee gets in their face.

// Siege dies to anything but walls.

// Garrisoning workers is free defense. Use it every time.

// Towers triple the value of whatever's inside them.

// The army that fights on its own terrain wins.

// Real armies are mixed. Pick a role to win, not the whole fight.

END OF DOCUMENT

FIELD MANUAL // COUNTERS // PRINTED FOR INTERNAL USE

PTOLEMIES / PLAYBOOK

DEFENSIVE-
AGGRESSIVE

FOUR PHASES

FOR THE TURTLE
WHO RAIDS

READ TOP-DOWN

PHASE 00

DOCTRINE // THE THREE LAWS

| READ ONCE

LAW 01 – COMMIT OR ABANDON

When a far base is attacked: **send your whole army, or write the base off.** Never trickle reinforcements.
Trickle = lose both army and base.

LAW 02 – STAND, DO NOT HIDE

Standing army **outside** the fort on aggressive stance.
Garrisoning is the panic button, not the strategy.

LAW 03 – TRAIN TO RATIO

No more spam-training. Hit the **40/30/10/15/5** ratio, then build villagers, not soldiers.

REF.01

UNIT LEGEND // FIVE ROLES

| /



WORKER

/ eco



SPEARMAN

/ anti-cav



ARCHER

/ ranged DPS



CAVALRY

/ scout + raid



SIEGE

/ anti-
building

PHASE 01 FOUNDATION // BOOM + SCOUT

| 00:00 – 06:00

OBJECTIVE

Build economy. Find the enemy. Don't fight.

STEP-BY-STEP

00:00 QUEUE 5 WOMEN 00:00 SCOUT OUTWARD IN ARC

00:30 4 FOOD / 2 WOOD 02:00 BARRACKS @ WOODLINE

04:00 LOCATE ENEMY CC 06:00 PHASE II AT 25 VIL

SCOUTING CHECKLIST

TARGET	WHY	PRIORITY
Enemy CC	Their army sits 20–30s away	HIGH
Their woodcutters	Best raid target. Far + soft	HIGH
Their mining	Far from base, often unprotected	MED
Their army comp	Don't push if you don't know	HIGH
Their walls/forts	If walled: boom. If not: pressure.	MED

// PITFALL

Don't fight with the scout cav. One dead horse = blind for 60 seconds.

PHASE 02

TRIPWIRE //

FORWARD PRESENCE

| 06:00 – 12:00

OBJECTIVE

Stop reacting. Start seeing. Build the wall before the gate is needed.

OUTPOSTS

x2

30s walk OUT from base, on approach paths. Tripwire, not bunker.

MERC CAMP

x1

Ptolemies bonus.
Forward, near outposts.
Reinforcements appear where you fight.

STANDING ARMY

15

6 pikes / 4 archers / 2 skirm / 3 cav.
AGGRESSIVE stance. Outside the fort.

CRITICAL SETTING

Every barracks rally point → forward outpost. Units never spawn idle. Never trickle to a fight in pieces.

FIRST RAID – 10:00

Send 3 cavalry to kill their woodcutters. Kill 4–6 workers, retreat the instant their army shows. Not a fight – a tax.

PHASE 03

PRESSURE // ACTIVE DEFENSE

| 12:00 – 20:00

ARMY COMPOSITION // 40 UNITS

PIKES 40%	ARCH 30%	SKM 10%	CAV 15%	SG 5%
16 PIKES	12 ARCHERS	4 SKIRM	6 CAV	2 SIEGE

THE HARASS LOOP

EVERY 90s → 3 cav to their woodline	KILL 4-6 → workers, retreat	NEVER FIGHT → their army	NEVER STOP → until you push
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FOUR GREEN LIGHTS TO ATTACK

1. You out-eco them +15 villagers. Convert eco lead into military.
2. Their army is on the wrong side of the map (raiding someone else).
3. You have siege + they have no walls. Walk in, break it, walk out.
4. They just lost a fight. Don't let them rebuild – push now.

THE FAR-BASE ATTACK – YOUR NEMESIS

DECIDE IN 5 SECONDS:

Army I can send now > their attacking army? → **COMMIT EVERYTHING.**

Army I can send now < theirs? → **WRITE OFF. COUNTER-ATTACK THEIR BASE.**

Never: "I'll send some to slow them down."

STRIKE // THE DECISIVE PUSH

PRE-PUSH CHECKLIST

☐ FULL ARMY 40+ units at ratio	☐ SIEGE READY 1-2 bolt shooters or rams
☐ ECO LEAD +15 villagers over them	☐ WALLS HOLD Home base safe if they counter
☐ TARGET CHOSEN Their second base, not main	☐ RETREAT PLAN In and out, don't overstay

ORDER OF OPERATIONS

1. March **whole army** to ONE target – usually their secondary base.
2. Kill the buildings, then retreat. Don't get into an attrition fight.
3. Wait 5 minutes. Their main is now starved of that base's income.
4. Push the main. Siege breaks walls, pikes hold their counter, archers kill workers.

// PITFALL

Do not push the main first. Their main has the most defenders. Take limbs before you take the heart.

MERCENARIES //

PIZZA DELIVERY

THE REFRAME

Mercenaries are NOT elite veterans you must protect. **They are military teleportation, paid for in metal.** They trade food/wood cost → metal cost, in return for fast spawning and forward placement.

MANTRA

Mercenaries are **pizza delivery**, not knights. Use them. Lose them. Reorder them.

FIVE TIMES TO USE THEM

1. **Forward Reinforcements** – camp near the fight. Units spawn 10s from front, not 60s.
2. **Emergency Defense** – attack incoming, drop camp at the choke, pump instantly.
3. **Metal-Rich Eco** – late game, metal overflowing, food tight. Mercs spend the right resource.
4. **Filling Comp Gaps** – need slingers fast, home barracks full? Merc camp covers it.
5. **Out-of-Position** – army fighting far from home. Drop a camp halfway across the map.

WHEN NOT TO USE

- Phase I (no metal yet)
- Food overflowing, metal tight
- As your main bulk army – citizens are cheaper

THE SIGNATURE MOVE: FORWARD MERC CAMP

10:00 VILLAGER FORWARD **10:30** MERC CAMP HALFWAY

11:00 CAMP ACTIVE **11:30** REINFORCE IN 10S

Under cover of your standing army, build a Merc Camp halfway to the enemy. Your forward outpost is now a unit factory. Reinforcements for any attack

spawn in 10 seconds. Devastating on Medium AI – the AI doesn't handle forward production well.

WHEN TO UNLOCK THE BIG STUFF

TIER	UNLOCKS	TARGET TIME
Phase II	Pikes, swordsmen, basic cav, towers, 2nd CC, blacksmith, merc camp	≈ 6–7 min (25 vil)
Phase III	Champions, war elephants, siege, embassy mercs, Wonder	≈ 15–18 min (50–60 vil)
First Champion	Sacred Band Inf or Cav. 5–10 max – hammer, not bulk.	≈ 16–18 min
First Elephant	Tank + building crusher. Pair with pikes + ranged.	≈ 18–20 min
First Siege	Bolt shooter. Wall-cracker for the decisive push.	≈ 16–18 min

TRAP

Don't rush Phase III. Phase III at min 12 with 30 villagers = you can **build** elephants but can't afford them. Phase III at min 18 with 60 villagers = you actually **use** it.

UPGRADE PRIORITY (RESEARCH IN THIS ORDER)

1. **Phase-ups** – non-negotiable
2. **Resource gathering upgrades** – pay back in <90s
3. **Blacksmith weapon + armor** – affects every combat unit
4. **Barracks pike upgrades** – you have 15+ pikes
5. **Ptolemies-unique techs** – farming, mercenary bonuses
6. **Unit-specific upgrades** – only if 8+ of that unit

→ Full economy curves, tripwires, and worker distribution in **VOL.05 – Economy + Upgrades**.

THE RULE

Champions are **force multipliers, not bulk**. 5-10 in your army, never 30.
Math: a champion costs 3-4× a citizen but is only ~2× as strong. **10 champions + 30 citizens beats 50 citizens** – because the champions create the line-break the citizens exploit.

THE PTOLEMIES ROSTER

CHAMPION	ROLE	WHEN TO BUILD
Champion Pikeman (Machimoi)	Flagship. Line-breaker, anti-cav, anti-elephant. Front rank.	First. Always.
Champion Infantry / Sword	Heavy melee. Breaks enemy pike walls.	If facing pike-heavy enemy.
Champion Cavalry	Elite cav for decisive flank. Not for raids.	For the decisive push only.
War Elephants	Tank + building crusher. Champion-tier role.	Phase III, with champion pikes as escort.

ARMY LAYERING WITH CHAMPIONS

FRONT CHAMPION PIKES **2ND** REGULAR PIKES **3RD** ARCHERS + SLINGERS

WINGS CAV **REAR** ELEPHANTS + SIEGE

DON'T

Don't **hoard** them (10 champions unused < 10 champions used). Don't **waste** them on raids (200 metal = 1 tower or 3 upgrades). Use them as the **hammer**; let citizens take the bulk of losses.

THE SIGNATURE LATE-GAME STACK

Champion Pikemen + War Elephants = the Ptolemies endgame composition. Elephants tank, champion pikes shred any cav that tries to flank, mass ranged behind does the killing. Very few clean counters before minute 20.

HEROES //

THE AURA

WHAT HEROES REALLY ARE

Unique named historical figures, trained at the Fortress in Phase III. **Only one of each at a time.** The real value isn't their combat – it's the **aura**, a passive buff to every friendly unit within ~30 tiles.

FUNDAMENTAL RULE

KEEP THEM ALIVE. A dead hero = no aura = ~15–20% army strength gone instantly. Cost + training time is massive. They are NOT champions. They cannot be lost casually.

THE THREE PTOLEMIES HEROES

HERO	BUFFS	PICK WHEN
 Ptolemy I Soter	Infantry attack & armor	Standard pike+sword army
 Ptolemy IV Philopator	Cavalry & elephants (he rides an elephant himself)	Elephant-heavy late game
 Cleopatra VII	Economic / training speed (varies by patch)	Long boom, eco focus

WHERE TO PUT THE HERO

Center of your army formation. Not the front (he dies). Not the back (aura doesn't reach the front line). Middle, surrounded by ~10 escort units. Move the hero, the aura moves with him.

BUILD TIMING

18:00 PHASE III + FIRST CHAMPIONS **19:00** BUILD/LOCATE FORTRESS

20:00 TRAIN HERO (~60–90S) **21:00** ASSIGN 5–10 ESCORTS

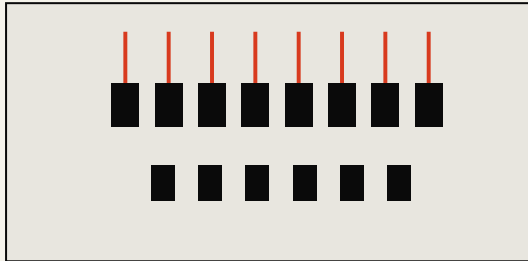
COMMON MISTAKES

- **✗** Sending hero alone to scout → dies to 3 spearmen
- **✗** Treating like a champion – heroes are not expendable
- **✗** Building all three at once – pick the one matching your army
- **✗** Building too early – Phase III, after you have an army
- **✗** Forgetting where he is in a chaotic fight

THE ENDGAME TRIO

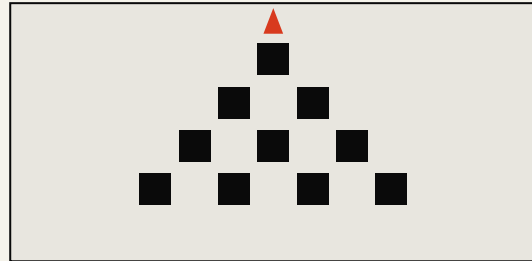
Ptolemy IV (on elephant) + 2 War Elephants + 8 Champion Pikemen = the Ptolemies signature endgame stack. Elephants tank, champions hold, hero's aura buffs the whole stack ~15%, Ptolemy IV himself rides in. Roll this with citizen + ranged support and you win most engagements.

// PHALANX



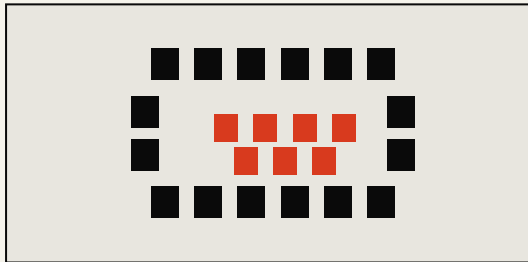
Pikes front, archers behind. Hold ground, defend chokes. Default formation.

// WEDGE



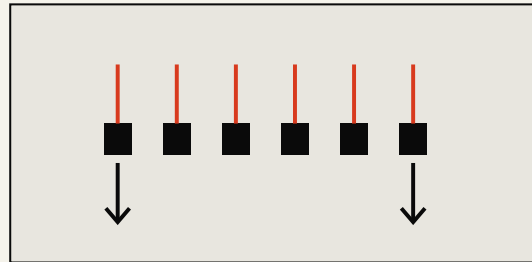
Cavalry only. Breaks through ranged lines. For raids and flanking pikes.

// BOX



Pikes face out, ranged inside. Surrounded? Outnumbered? Box up and survive.

// SKIRMISH



Spread wide, throw, retreat, repeat. Counter slow melee blobs. Never melee.

YOU DO THIS	DO THIS INSTEAD
Spam-train units randomly	Train to 40/30/10/15/5 ratio. Pause when met. Build villagers.
Garrison only when raided	Standing army OUTSIDE fort, aggressive stance. Garrison = emergency only.
Drip reinforcements to a losing fight	Commit fully OR write off & counter. Never in between.
Expand faster than you can defend	Each new base = its own fort + outpost or it doesn't exist.
Defend, defend, defend	3-cav harass loop every 90s. Tax their economy constantly.
Stop scouting after the start	One cav on permanent enemy patrol. Replace instantly if it dies.

ENDPLATE

EVERY GAME // IN
ORDER

| MEMORIZE

01 SCOUT Enemy by 4:00	02 BOOM 25 vil before phase	03 TRIPWIRE 2 outposts forward	04 STAND 15-unit ball, aggressive
05 HARASS 3 cav, every 90s	06 COMPOSE 40/30/10/15/5	07 COMMIT All-in or write off	08 STRIKE Limbs first, then heart

END OF DOCUMENT

FIELD MANUAL // PTOLEMIES // PRINTED FOR INTERNAL USE

ATTACK/STRATEGIES

SEVEN PATTERNS

FROM TURTLE TO
STRIKER

EVERY HIT HAS A
PURPOSE

NEVER MARCH
BLIND

// DOCTRINE – READ THIS FIRST

LAW 01 – ATTACKING IS DEFENDING

If their army is at home defending, it can't be at your base attacking. **The best defense is making them defend.**

LAW 02 – STRIKE WHEN THEY ARE WEAK

Don't attack when YOU feel ready. Attack when **THEY are vulnerable.** Two different questions.

LAW 03 – EVERY ATTACK HAS A SCRIPT

Target. Success condition. Failure condition. **No blind marches.** If you can't answer these three before clicking, don't go.

// BEFORE YOU PRESS ATTACK

Answer all three. Out loud. Every single time.

01

TARGET

What am I trying to kill? A building? Workers? Their army? Be specific.

02

SUCCESS

When do I declare victory and retreat? "Their lumber camp falls" not "they die."

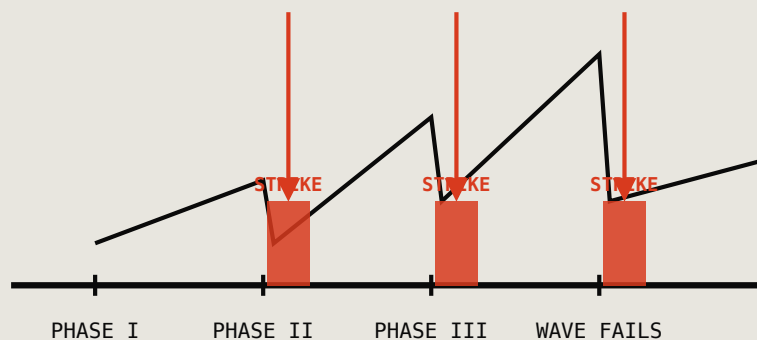
03

FAILURE

When do I cut losses? "Their army shows up with 20+ units" or "I lose 5 cav."

ENEMY ARMY SIZE OVER TIME

VALLEYS = OPENINGS



// THE MOVE

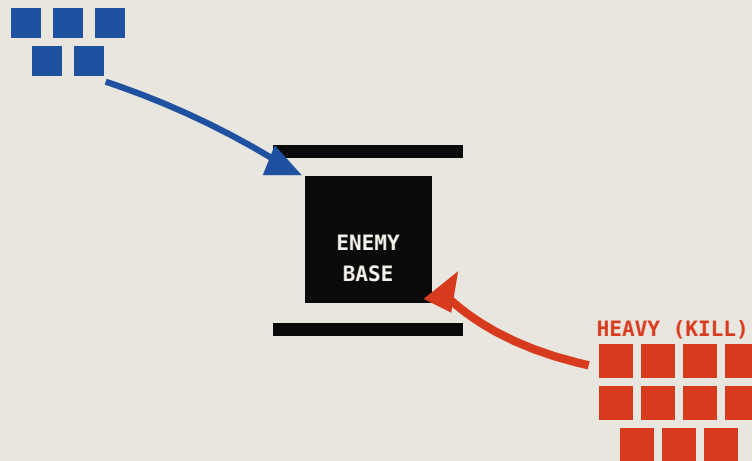
Pick the moment **they** are weakest, not when **you** feel strong. The window matters more than the army.

// BEST WINDOWS

Just phased up Their bank is empty. No new units mid-animation.	Their push failed Their army is depleted. Counter immediately.
Army is mid-map Their base is empty. Sneak in.	You teched up first Your units stronger 1-for-1.

Drill: Set a mental alarm – when scout sees their CC's Phase II finish, you push. Don't wait.

STEP 1: BAIT FROM TOP → STEP 2: HIT FROM SIDE
LIGHT (BAIT)



// THE MOVE

Two armies, two angles, simultaneous. Their army can only face ONE direction. Make them choose: defend the front or defend the flank – they lose either way.

// SETUP

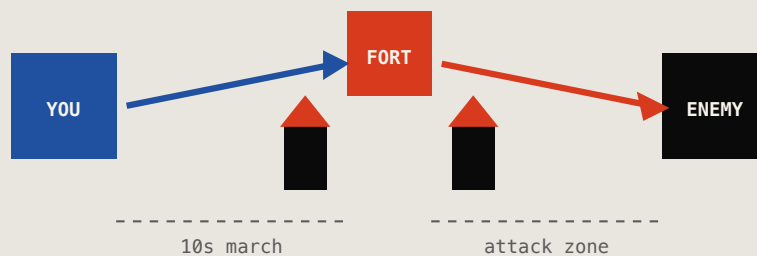
1. **Light army** attacks from one direction (the distraction)
2. Wait until their army commits to defend it
3. **Heavy army** smashes in from the opposite side
4. Their army can't get back in time

You already did this once. Accidentally. Now do it on purpose. Every game.

TOWER DROP

// FORWARD BASE

DON'T BRING AN ARMY –
BRING A BASE



REINFORCE: 10s INSTEAD OF 60s

// THE MOVE

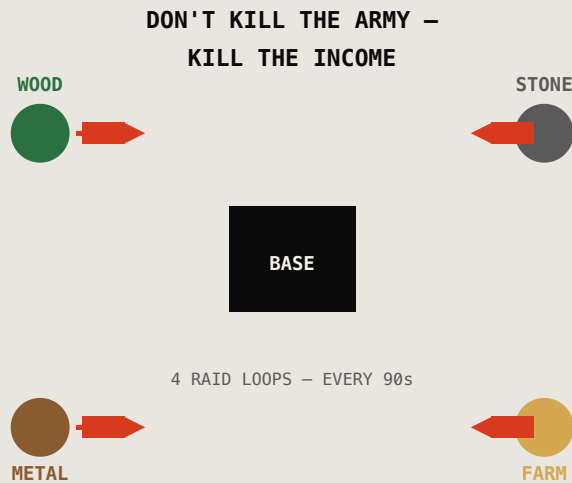
Send 2–3 villagers + 5 soldiers halfway to their base. Build a tower → barracks → another tower. Now you have **local reinforcements** – every new unit walks 10 seconds, not 60.

// WHY IT WRECKS MEDIUM AI

- AI throws units at it piecemeal
- You out-trade because reinforcements come fast
- It's a foothold for the real push later

Cost: 2 minutes of 1 villager's time. **Value:** half the map permanently yours.

THE ECO STARVE



// THE MOVE

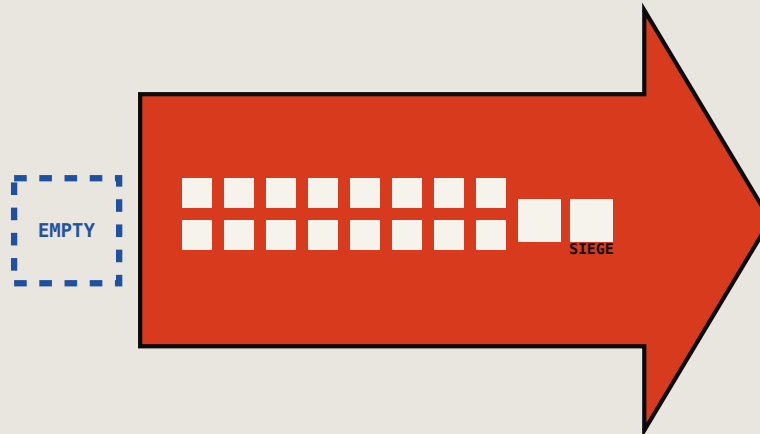
Don't fight their army. Strangle their economy. After 5 minutes of this, their army stops growing – they can't afford it.

// THE 4 RAID LOOPS

- **Loop 1:** 3 cav on their woodcutters, every 90s
- **Loop 2:** Tower drop on their mining outpost
- **Loop 3:** Outposts on neutral resources (deny them)
- **Loop 4:** 5 cav circling farms, killing gathering women

Then: when their army shrinks, push with your full force.

EVERYTHING. ONE DIRECTION.



WIN HERE OR LOSE HERE.

// THE MOVE

Empty your base. Empty your barracks rally. Send EVERYTHING. Plus 5 villagers to build a tower at the edge of their base mid-fight.

// WHEN TO ALL-IN

- You have an eco lead AND a comp advantage
- They just lost a fight and can't reinforce in time
- You have siege ready and they have no walls

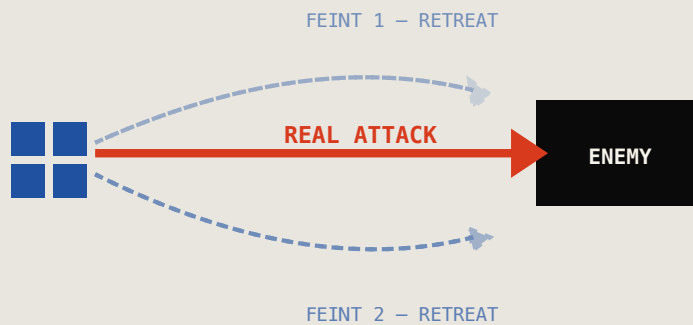
The rule: Win or lose, decide it here. **Don't dribble back home.** The all-in is a commitment.

// WARNING

Lose this and the game's over – your base is empty. Only call it when the math is in your favor.

EXHAUST THEIR ATTENTION FIRST

FAKE, FAKE, FAKE – THEN HIT



// THE MOVE

Push toward their base with half your army. They panic, pull workers, mobilize army to defend. Just before contact – **RETREAT**.

Repeat 2–3 times. Now they're paranoid AND exhausted from running back and forth.

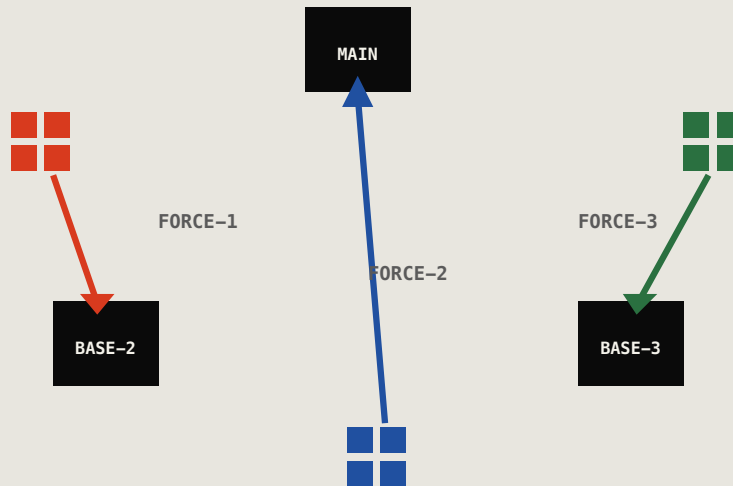
// WHAT YOU GAIN

- They wasted villager work-time defending nothing
- Their army is now out of position
- You lost zero units
- The 4th attack – real, with siege – catches them flat

Costs you: nothing. **Costs them:** attention, mobility, and 4–5 minutes of eco.

THREE-PRONGED ATTACK

THEY CAN DEFEND TWO. NEVER THREE.



// THE MOVE

Three small armies, three angles, three targets. They can defend two of them at best. The third one falls.

// SETUP

- Each force = 12–15 units (combined arms, lightweight)
- One force per target. Don't merge mid-attack.
- Pre-position them BEFORE attacking. They walk for 30s, you can't react after.

// THE TRAP

You will lose track of one force. Accept this. Designate the most-disposable one as the "diversion" – even if it dies, it bought time for the other two.

Master move: Use this after a feint pattern. They expect another fake – they ignore one of your forces. That's the one that breaks through.

IF...	USE PATTERN
They just phased up	01 Timing
You have 2 separate armies forming	02 Pincer
You want a foothold near them	03 Forward Base
Their army is bigger than yours	04 Eco Starve
You're ahead and want to end it	05 All-In
You need to position before striking	06 Feint
Late game, they have multiple bases	07 Three-Pronged

END OF DOCUMENT

FIELD MANUAL // ATTACK PATTERNS // PRINTED FOR INTERNAL USE

DEFENSE/STRATEGIES

WHEN YOU ARE
OUTMATCHED

TERRAIN FIGHTS
FIRST

SACRIFICE WITH
PURPOSE

SURVIVE TO
STRIKE

DOCTRINE

THREE LAWS OF DEFENSE

| READ FIRST

LAW 01 – When outmatched, your army is NOT the front line. **Terrain + infrastructure fights first.** The army is the closer.

LAW 02 – Buildings can be rebuilt. **Armies take three minutes to retrain.** Save the army, not the bricks.

LAW 03 – Every sacrifice must have a purpose. **"Did those troops buy me more than they cost?"** If yes, it was a good play – regardless of body count.

When their army comes, things die in this order. You want their army at **20% HP** by the time it reaches Layer 03.

01

TERRAIN

WALLS + CHOKEPOINTS

The map itself fighting for you. They have to walk through narrow passes, around walls, through gates. Costs them 30+ seconds and takes the first chip damage.

02

BUILDINGS

TOWERS + FORTS (WITH GARRISONED ARCHERS)

The actual damage dealers. Tower + 5 archers garrisoned = death machine. Upgrades stack. This is where their army should bleed out.

03

ARMY

YOUR STANDING ARMY (BEHIND THE WALL)

Sortie out to finish off survivors. Kill any siege approaching the wall. Don't engage the full attacking force head-on – let the towers wear them down first.

04

INSURANCE

VILLAGERS GARRISONED IN CC + HOUSES

If everything else falls, the villagers survive. As long as they live, you can rebuild. As long as the CC stands, you can train new units.

The mistake you keep making: rushing Layer 03 (your army) out to meet them in the open. Without Layer 01 and 02 doing their job first, your army fights at 1:1. Behind the wall, you fight at 3:1.

THE SACRIFICE DOCTRINE

Every great defense in history involved **deliberate sacrifice**. Some units exist to die so the rest can win. Stop trying to save every soldier – start asking *which sacrifice buys what you need*.

// SCREENING FORCE

5–8 cheap spearmen blocking a choke. Their job: slow the enemy 20 seconds. Their death is the budget.

Historical: rearguards at every retreating army from Rome to Napoleon.

// DIVERSION

Light army hitting a secondary base. They might all die. Their death pulled the enemy's main army out of position.

Historical: countless flanking feints – they exist to draw attention, not to win.

// REARGUARD

The last 3–4 units cover your retreat. They body-block pursuit. Without them, your retreating army is chased and killed from behind.

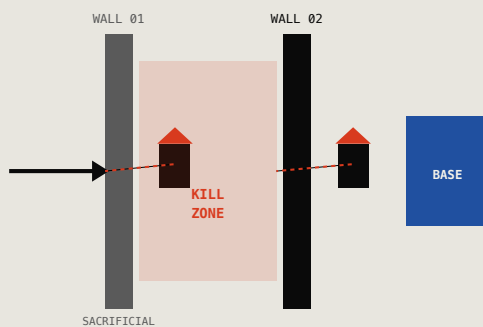
Historical: Thermopylae – 300 stayed so Greece could retreat. Bought 3 days = saved Greece.

// TOWER BAIT

Let a tower fall on purpose. Their army stops to attack wood. You reposition. Ambush from behind while they're chopping.

Historical: scorched earth tactics – surrender the building, keep the army.

The mental shift: from "I must save every unit" to "what's the cheapest sacrifice that buys what I need?" Once that clicks, you stop panicking when 5 units die.

// THE SETUP

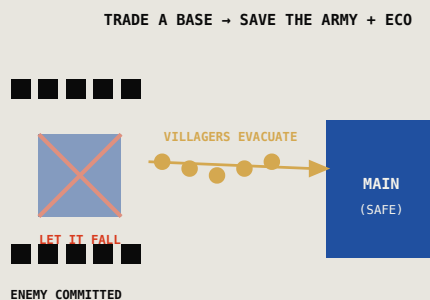
1. **Wall 01** – forward wall, expected to fall
2. Towers behind Wall 01 shoot at them while they break it
3. They breach → enter the **kill zone** between walls
4. Towers from both sides shred them
5. **Wall 02** still standing. They face it exhausted.

// WHY IT WORKS

Their army loses 30–40% HP just getting to your real defense. The first wall is **scheduled to die** – that's its purpose.

Cheapest insurance in the game.
200 stone for Wall 01 saves you 800+ resources of dead units.

CONTROLLED RETREAT



// THE MOVE

The enemy has committed to attacking your far base. Don't reinforce.

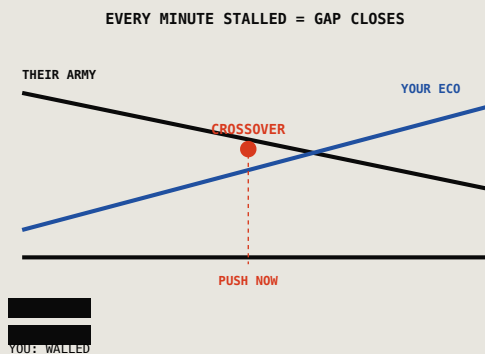
1. **Evacuate the villagers** back to main
2. Let the base fall
3. Save the army
4. Buildings rebuild. Armies take 3 minutes.

// THE MATH

Base value: ~600 wood + ~400 stone
= rebuildable.

Army value: ~3000+ resources, 3 minutes of production time. **Not rebuildable in time.**

Hardest part: watching the base die. Do it anyway. It's the same calculus as the chess sacrifice.



// THE MOVE

They have a bigger army but a smaller eco. **Don't fight.** Wall up, tower up, sit in your kill box.

// WHAT'S HAPPENING

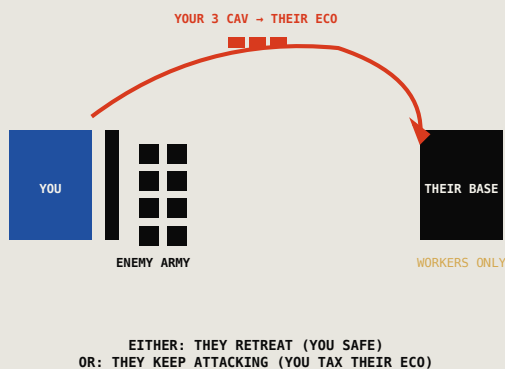
- Every minute: you tech up, train villagers, build infrastructure
- Every minute: they spend resources on attacks that bounce off walls
- They can't afford to keep attacking forever
- The army gap closes. Then crosses.

The clock is your ally. Stay alive 5 more minutes and the math flips.

// DON'T

Don't sortie out to "test" them. Stay behind the wall until you have decisive force.

RAID WHILE DEFENDING



// THE MOVE

Even while being attacked, send your 3-cav raid squad to **THEIR** woodline. Yes, really.

// WHY IT'S BRILLIANT

Their army is committed to attacking you. To save their workers, they'd have to **break off the attack**. They have two choices:

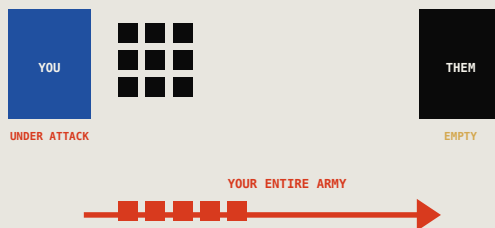
- **Retreat** → your base is saved, you didn't even fight
- **Keep attacking** → they lose workers at home AND your towers still bleed them

Both outcomes are wins for you.

The principle: when defending, never just defend. Make them pay attention to two things at once.

THE COUNTER- COMMIT

THEIR ARMY HITS YOUR BASE
YOUR ARMY HITS THEIR BASE
FIRST TO RETREAT LOSES



// THE MOVE

Their entire army is at your wall. **Their base is empty.** Send YOUR full army the other way – to THEIR base.

// THE TRADE

They take a base. You take a base. But because their army has to walk all the way back, **you usually finish first.**

// PRE-REQUISITES

- Your villagers can survive 60–90 seconds without your army (towers + walls)
- Your army has siege or can break their CC fast
- You've accepted the trade in advance – no half-measures

"Whoever blinks first loses."

Make them blink – make them recall.

AM I ABOUT TO THROW MY ARMY AWAY?

QUESTION 01

Is their army bigger than mine right now?

NO → ENGAGE

Standing army comes out. Fight at the wall. Win the trade.

QUESTION 02 – IF YES

Do I have walls + towers between them and my army?

YES → STALL

Stay behind defenses. Garrison archers. Let towers + walls do 70% of the work. Send raid cav to their economy.

QUESTION 03 – IF NO

Is the base they're attacking my MAIN base?

NO → LET IT FALL

Evacuate villagers. Save the army. Counter-attack their base for the trade.

**YES + DESPERATE
→ COUNTER-COMMIT**

Send your full army to their base. Race. First to finish wins. **No half-measures.**

The one question you must NEVER answer "yes" to: "Should I send some units to slow them down?" That's the trickle trap. It's always the wrong answer.

SITUATION	PATTERN
Standard defensive posture	01 Kill Box
Long siege expected	02 Layered Walls
Far base, outmatched, can't save it	03 Controlled Retreat
They're bigger but you have better eco	04 The Stall
You're defending but want pressure	05 Raid While Defending
Main base under attack, their base empty	06 Counter-Commit

END OF DOCUMENT

FIELD MANUAL // DEFENSE PATTERNS // PRINTED FOR INTERNAL USE

SCOUTING/EYES

SEE BEFORE THEY	ASK A QUESTION	DEATH IS DATA	OUTPOSTS DON'T
SEE YOU	FIRST		DIE

DOCTRINE THREE LAWS OF SCOUTING | READ FIRST

LAW 01 – A scout's job is **information, not combat**. If it's fighting, it's failed.

LAW 02 – Scout **WITH a question**, not "to look around." A specific question changes where you send the scout.

LAW 03 – The map is uncontested in Phase I. **Build outposts before you need them**. Once the map heats up, you can't sneak out to place them.

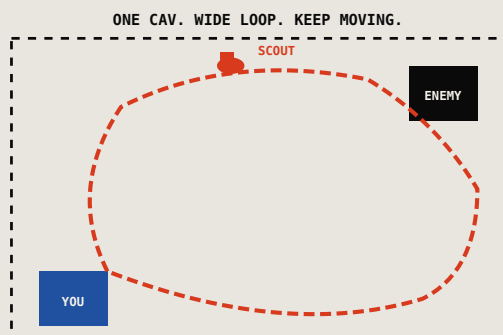
A scout is any unit you send to **gather information instead of fight**.

Ptolemies start with a camel – that IS your scout. Most civs start with one cavalry unit for this purpose.

The intelligence you're after:

- Where is the enemy base?
- Where is their army right now?
- What units are they building?
- Are they teching / expanding / preparing to attack?
- What resources are they on?

The information gap is the strategic gap. A blind player loses to a slightly weaker player with vision.



// THE TOOL

Send your starting cav on a wide loop around the map. It's fast, free, and reveals huge amounts of map in the first 4 minutes.

// WHEN IT WORKS

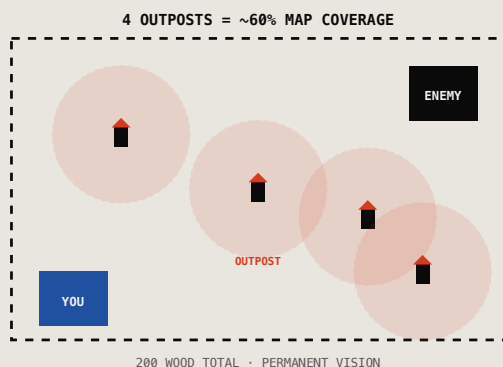
Phase I (0-6 min). The map is empty. No one has built units yet. Your cav can ride right past their CC and live.

// WHEN IT STOPS WORKING

When the enemy has units patrolling – usually by minute 8-10. Your cav starts dying.

The rule: Always keep ONE cav alive on patrol. If it dies, replace it within 30 seconds. The fog-of-war is what's killing your far bases.

OUTPOSTS & WATCHTOWERS



// THE TOOL

50 wood per outpost. Permanent vision in a circle around them. They can be killed, but only with effort – usually requiring siege.

// WHERE TO PLACE

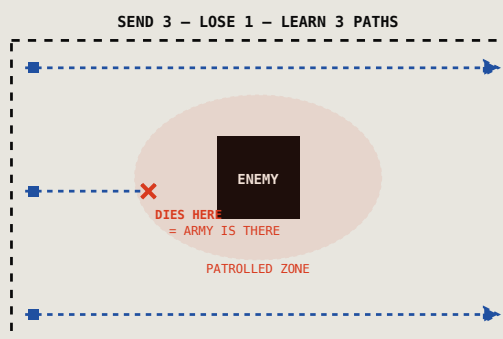
- Hills & ridges (extended sight)
- Map edges (rarely patrolled)
- Choke points NEAR enemy approach
- Neutral resource deposits (denies + scouts)

// CRITICAL TIMING

Build them in Phase I-II, while the map is uncontested. Once the enemy roams, you can't sneak villagers out to place them.

The single biggest scouting fix: 4 outposts by minute 8.
Cost: 200 wood. Value: permanent vision for the rest of the game.

EDGE PROBES & SACRIFICES



// THE TOOL

Send cheap throwaway units along multiple paths simultaneously. **Some will die.** Where they die tells you where the enemy army is.

// HOW IT WORKS

1. Send 3 cav (or spearmen) along 3 different paths – top edge, middle, bottom edge
2. Map edges are rarely patrolled – those usually survive
3. If the middle one dies, the enemy army is along the middle
4. You learned 3 paths of info for the cost of 1 cheap unit

// THE MINDSET

A dead scout is not a wasted scout. **Where it died is the intel.** Death = data.

Use this when you can't get a live scout close. Late game, this is often your only option.

Beginners scout randomly. Pros scout with a **specific question** they're trying to answer. The question changes WHERE you send the scout, WHEN, and what you're looking at.

// Is their army still at home?	Send cav toward their CC. If it dies fast → army is home. If it reaches the CC → army is out somewhere else.
// Are they teching to Phase III?	Look at their CC for the phase-up upgrade animation. Or scan for new building shapes: Forts, Embassies, Wonders.
// Did they expand to that resource?	Patrol the natural expansion points – stone, metal, second CC spots. Workers there = they expanded.
// Are they about to attack?	Look for: army gathering at chokepoints, forward outposts being built, tower being placed near you.
// What's their army composition?	Sneak cav close enough to see units, then retreat. You only need 2 seconds of vision. Note ratios, retreat.
// Where is the weak point I should attack?	Patrol around their base – find the side with fewest towers, no walls, exposed workers.

The shift: from "I should scout" to "I need to know X – let me confirm." Specific question, specific tool, specific time.

// PHASE I

0-6 MIN

Cavalry loop. Map is uncontested. One cav, ride wide circle. Find enemy CC by minute 4.
Build first 2 outposts at map edges.

// PHASE II

6-12 MIN

Cav + outposts. Cav still works but riskier. Build 2 more outposts at chokes. Patrol cav stays alive – replaces if killed.

// PHASE III+

12 MIN – END

Outposts + edge probes. Cav can't get close anymore. Read from your outposts. Send sacrificial probes when you need fresh data.

SYMPTOM	FIX
Cav dies at the same spot every time	That spot is their patrol. Go around it via map edge.
Cav dies before reaching their base	Map is contested. Switch to outposts + edge probes.
Can't see anything because of fog	You didn't place outposts in Phase I-II. Lesson for next game.
Lose vision the moment cav dies	Always have 2 scouts, not 1. Replace BEFORE the first dies.
Scout finds nothing interesting	You're scouting without a question. Form a hypothesis first.
Enemy attacks surprise you anyway	You aren't scouting often enough. Set a 60s mental timer.

1. **Minute 1:** Start your cav loop. Find enemy by minute 4.
2. **Minute 6:** Build outposts 1-2 at safe map edges.
3. **Minute 10:** Build outposts 3-4 at chokepoints near approaches.
4. **Every 60 seconds:** ask one specific question. Send a scout to answer it.
5. **When cav stops surviving:** switch to edge probes + outpost reading.
6. **If you ever lose vision:** immediately replace the dead scout. Don't wait.
7. **Death is data:** if a probe dies, you learned where the enemy is.
8. **The information gap is the strategic gap.** Vision wins games.

END OF DOCUMENT

FIELD MANUAL // SCOUTING // PRINTED FOR INTERNAL USE

ECONOMY+UPGRADES

FLOW NOT
STOCKPILE

| SPEND OR BLEED

| UPGRADES ARE
PROFIT

| MERCS ARE PIZZA

DOCTRINE THREE LAWS OF ECONOMY | READ FIRST

LAW 01 – Economy is **FLOW**, not **STOCKPILE**. A bank of 2000 wood is a frozen economy. Income → spending → income → spending. Don't hoard.

LAW 02 – Every upgrade is **profit**. Most pay back in 60–90 seconds. Not researching them = leaving free resources on the table every minute.

LAW 03 – Upgrades only matter if you have units to benefit. **Buy bodies before you buy boosts**. 3 units with a buff < 6 units without.

REF.01 THE FOUR RESOURCES | EACH HAS A JOB

Resources aren't interchangeable. Each does a specific job. Knowing which you need shapes what you build.

FOOD

/ GROWTH

Villagers, basic infantry, farms. Your **growth** resource. Constantly draining.

WOOD

/
INFRASTRUCTURE

Buildings, ranged units, ships, outposts. Your **infrastructure** resource.

STONE

/ DEFENSE

Walls, towers, mining camps. Your **defense** resource. Underused by beginners.

METAL

/ TECH + ELITE

Champions, upgrades, advanced units, siege. Your **tech** resource. Phase III drinks this.

// GENERIC DISTRIBUTION

PHASE I (0-6 MIN)



PHASE II (6-12 MIN)



PHASE III (12+ MIN)

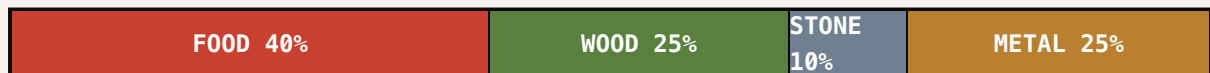
// PTOLEMIES-SPECIFIC (YOUR CIV)

Why different: Ptolemies have cheaper farms, cheaper pikes, mercenary camps (less wood needed for forward production), and metal-hungry champions + elephants in Phase III.

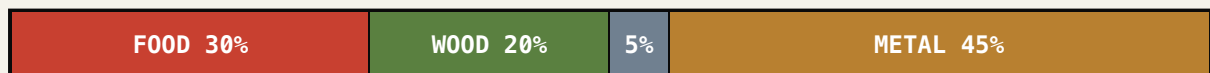
PHASE I - PTOLEMIES



PHASE II - PTOLEMIES



PHASE III - PTOLEMIES



Ptolemies key insight: you can run lower wood than most civs because mercenary camps replace the need for multiple forward barracks. That wood becomes food and metal.

TRIPWIRES

YOUR HOARDING CURE

| SPEND THE MOMENT YOU CROSS

Set these as mental tripwires. The instant any number crosses, do the listed action. Repeat forever. **Resources don't earn interest. Move them.**

FOOD	WOOD	STONE	METAL
> 500	> 400	> 200	> 200
→ queue more villagers in CC + train units	→ farm, barracks, tower, outpost	→ drop a tower or wall section	→ research an upgrade or champion

WHEN TO UNLOCK BIGGER TROOPS

I VILLAGE	// ECO-ONLY PHASE Citizen soldiers only. Basic spearmen, archers, slingers, scout cav. Don't try to fight wars here. Build economy.	0 → 6 MIN
II TOWN	// REAL MILITARY Unlocks pikemen, swordsmen, basic cav variants, towers, second CC, blacksmith (start upgrading!), mercenary camp (Ptolemies bonus).	6 → 12 MIN at 25 villagers
III CITY	// THE ELITE PHASE Unlocks champions, war elephants, siege, Wonders , advanced upgrades, embassy mercenaries. First champion ≈ min 16–18, first elephant ≈ min 18–20.	12 → 18 MIN at 50–60 vil

The trap: Don't rush Phase III. Phase III at minute 12 with 30 villagers = you can BUILD elephants but can't AFFORD them. Phase III at minute 18 with 60 villagers = you actually USE it.

// CHAMPIONS ARE NOT BULK UNITS

Build 5–10 champions, never 40. They're **force multipliers** – your hammer. Citizens are your anvil.

THE UPGRADE PRIORITY LADDER

Most upgrades pay themselves back in 60–90 seconds. After that = pure profit. Skipping them is leaving free resources on the table.

This is the order to research. Top = highest ROI.

01

Phase-ups – Phase II at ~min 6, Phase III at ~min 15.
Unlocks everything.

ALWAYS**02**

Resource gathering rate – wood/stone/metal +X% from storage/farmstead. ROI in <90s.

ALWAYS**03**

Blacksmith Weapon +1/+2/+3 – affects EVERY combat unit. Every game, every tier.

ALWAYS**04**

Blacksmith Armor +1/+2/+3 – same as weapon. Stacks with everything.

ALWAYS**05**

Barracks pike upgrades – if you have 15+ pikes (you do).

USUALLY**06**

Civ-unique bonus techs – Ptolemies has good ones (farming, mercenaries). Look at your bonus tree.

USUALLY**07**

Stable-specific cav upgrades – only if you have 8+ of that cav type. Below that, buy bodies instead.

CONDITIONAL**08**

Champion-specific upgrades – only after you've actually built champions in numbers.

CONDITIONAL**09**

Naval upgrades – only on water maps.

SKIP

The math: Blacksmith +1 weapon on a 40-unit army > stable spear-cav upgrade on 3 cav. The wider your upgrade reaches, the higher the ROI.

// THE REFRAME

Mercenaries are NOT elite veterans you must protect. **They are military teleportation, paid for in metal.** They trade food/wood cost → metal cost, and in return give you fast spawning and forward placement.

Mantra: Mercenaries are pizza delivery, not knights. Use them. Lose them. Reorder them.

// FIVE TIMES TO USE THEM

1. **Forward Reinforcements** – build a Merc Camp near the fight. Units spawn 10s from the front instead of 60s.
2. **Emergency Defense** – attack incoming, drop a camp at the choke, pump units instantly.
3. **Metal-Rich Eco** – late game, you have 600 metal and food can't keep up. Mercs spend metal instead.
4. **Filling Composition Gaps** – need slingers fast, home barracks full? Merc camp handles it.
5. **Out-of-Position Reinforcement** – army fighting far from home, drop a camp halfway across the map.

// WHEN NOT TO USE

- Phase I (no metal yet)
- Food overflowing, metal tight
- As your **main bulk** army – citizens are cheaper

// THE PTOLEMIES SIGNATURE: FORWARD MERC CAMP

Around minute 10-12:

1. Send 1 villager to a spot halfway to the enemy
2. Build a Mercenary Camp under cover of your standing army
3. Now your forward outpost is also a unit factory
4. Reinforcements for any attack spawn in 10 seconds

This is the Ptolemies signature move. Devastating on Medium AI – the AI doesn't handle forward production well.

EXPAND

SECOND CC // WHEN + WHERE

| DOUBLE THE ECO

A second Civic Centre gives you: a second source of villager production, a second food-gathering hub, vision & map control.

// THE RULE

Drop your second CC **when Phase II completes**, on the closest unclaimed resource cluster – usually stone or metal.

// ONE CC IS FINE FOR EASY. YOU NEED TWO FOR MEDIUM AND UP.

Reason: a single CC can only produce villagers at one queue. Medium AI runs two queues. You need to match production or fall behind on workers.

// DON'T DROP A CC IF

- You can't defend it (no walls/towers within 30s walk)
- It's in the open with no natural choke
- You're under attack right now (build a fort first, expand later)

WORKER DISTRIBUTION BY PHASE

Rule: **women** → **food only**. Citizen-soldiers → wood, stone, metal (faster than women at those).

PHASE	TOTAL WORKERS	FOOD	WOOD	STONE	METAL
PHASE I	~25	10 (women)	10 (men)	3 (men)	2 (men)
PHASE II	~40 + 15 army	15 (women)	12 (men)	5 (men)	5 (men)
PHASE III	~65 + 40 army	25 (women)	15 (men)	5 (men)	15 (men)
PUSH	~70 + 50 army	25	15	5	20

Standing army NEVER gathers. Working soldiers are reserves. Pull them only in emergency or for the final push.

ECONOMY HABITS

1. **Economy is flow.** Spend the moment you cross a tripwire.
2. **Women on food. Men on wood/stone/metal.** Never mix.
3. **Standing army never gathers.** Working soldiers are reserves.
4. **Always queue villagers in the CC.** Always. Until you have 70.
5. **Two CCs by minute 12.** One queue is not enough.
6. **Phase II at 25 vil. Phase III at 50-60.** Not earlier, not later.
7. **Always research Phase-ups, gather techs, blacksmith.** Free profit.
8. **Mercenaries are pizza delivery.** Use the forward camp.

MAP/READING

THE MAP IS A
STRATEGY

MINIMAP IS YOUR
FIRST SCOUT

MIRROR LAW

LET TERRAIN
FIGHT

DOCTRINE

THREE LAWS OF MAP READING

| READ FIRST

LAW 01 – Every map is a strategy. **The terrain is telling you how to play** if you can read it. Don't force one playstyle on every map.

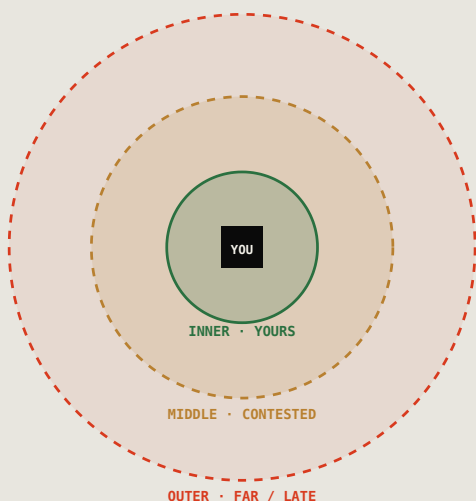
LAW 02 – The minimap is your **first scout**. Read it for 10 seconds before sending a single unit.

LAW 03 – Maps are mostly mirrored. **What you have near you, they have near them**. Use this for prediction.

THE MINIMAP IS YOUR FIRST SCOUT

0 A.D. color-codes resources on the minimap. You can see the resource layout of the entire map before moving a single unit. Take 10 seconds at game start to actually *look*.

				
FOOD	WOOD	STONE	METAL	WATER
red dots – berries, animals, hunt	green pockets – forest clusters	grey clumps – deposits	orange/brown – rarer, contested	blue – fishing, transport, barrier



// INNER RING (WITHIN 20S WALK)

Yours. Exploit fully. Berries, sheep, near forests, near stone. Your villagers gather here without escort.

// MIDDLE RING (20-40S WALK)

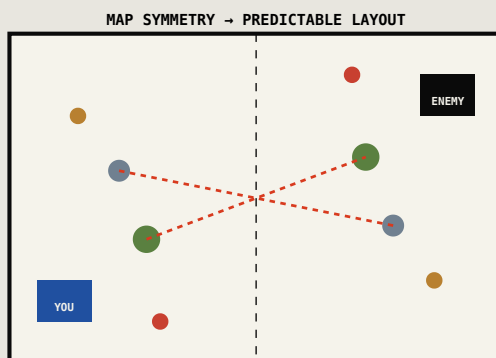
Second CC territory. **Contested with enemy**. Most fights happen here. Drop your second CC at the resource cluster closest to a defensible position.

// OUTER RING (40S+ WALK)

Far resources. Only viable **late game** or via aggressive expansion + forts. Expanding here without infrastructure = giving the enemy free kills.

Use this: draw the rings mentally at game start. It tells you where to expand and where the fights will happen.

THE MIRROR PRINCIPLE



// THE INSIGHT

Most 0 A.D. maps are **roughly symmetric**. If you have a stone deposit 20 tiles north of your CC, the enemy almost certainly has one 20 tiles north of theirs.

// WHAT IT LETS YOU PREDICT

- **Where they'll expand** – the same resource clusters you'd take
- **Where contested fights happen** – between equivalent resource pockets
- **Where to scout first** – mirror your own resource positions across the map
- **What civ-shape they're playing** – same map, same options

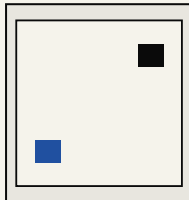
Use it like this: "I have stone close, so they do too. Their second CC will go there. That's where I'll harass."

SHAPES

FIVE MAP ARCHETYPES

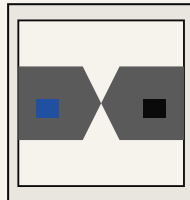
| EACH ASKS A STRATEGY

Almost every map falls into one of these shapes. Each has a distinct "correct" approach.



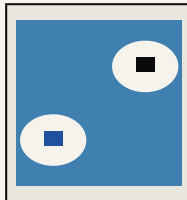
OPEN

Flat, no chokes. Combined arms. Walling is useless. Cav harass + mobility wins.



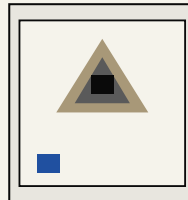
CHOKE

Narrow passes. Walls + towers paradise. Turtle + raid wins.



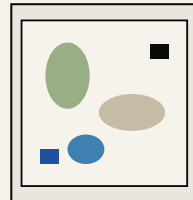
ISLAND

Water between. Ships matter. Slow tempo, naval economy.



HIGHLAND

High ground in middle. Control the heights = win. Vertical positioning.



ASYMMETRIC

Mixed terrain. Scout MORE. Vision matters more than usual.

At game start, before clicking anything:

TIME	WHAT TO LOOK AT
0-5s	Scan minimap for resource colors. Where's wood, stone, metal?
5-10s	Identify nearest food, wood, stone, metal within 20s walk.
10-15s	Look at terrain: hills, water, choke points. What archetype is this?
15-20s	Guess enemy position. Largest empty zone on minimap = probably them.
20-30s	Pick first 2 villager assignments + scout direction.

30 seconds sets up your whole game. Skip this and you spend the next 5 minutes catching up.

The TYPE of resources tells you what army to build. The map is whispering. Listen.

WHAT THE MAP HAS	WHAT IT'S ASKING
Lots of trees, dense forests	Wood-rich → mass ranged armies cheaply
Open ground, few obstacles	Cav-friendly → mobile play, no point walling
Lots of stone deposits	Wall up, tower-heavy defense
Lots of metal	Push for champions / elephants late
Few resources overall	Small armies, tech rush, no waste
Hunt-rich (deer, boar)	Cav useful for hunt + harass
Water-heavy	Build a dock, get fishing boats

TERRAIN

NATURAL FEATURES AS WEAPONS

| THE MAP IS BUILDING FOR YOU

FEATURE	USE IT AS
Hills / high ground	Outpost vision range +. Tower attack range +. Place defense here.
Cliffs	Impassable. Free walls. Build with cliff at your back, only wall the open side.
Forests	Slow movement, hide units. Ambush positions. Wood income.
Water	Fishing income, transport, natural barrier on that side.
Bridges / fords	Often the ONLY way across. Wall them – instant kill zone.
Narrow passes	Mountain or canyon gaps. The map's free choke point.

The map already built half your defense. Just complete it. Don't fight terrain – use it.

STATE

READING THE GAME STATE

| AHEAD / EQUAL / BEHIND

Beyond the map itself: where is the GAME? Check the score, population, military, and tech. Then make decisions based on which side of the ledger you're on.

// THE FOUR METRICS THAT MATTER

- **Villager count** – biggest leading indicator. +15 villagers = winning.
- **Military count + composition** – are you behind in numbers OR in tech?
- **Phase progress** – who's in Phase III first?
- **Map control** – how many of your buildings are OUTSIDE your starting area?

// DECISION MATRIX

 AHEAD	 EQUAL	 BEHIND
Press the advantage. Push, raid, expand. Don't let them catch up. Tech up to widen the gap.	Look for openings. Scout aggressively. Find the unbalanced spot – their weak flank, their thin eco – and concentrate force.	Stall + scale. Wall up, tower up, sit. Don't engage. The clock is your ally – tech up and let their advantage erode.

// THE HONEST CHECK (EVERY 90 SECONDS)

1. Am I ahead, equal, or behind on each metric?
2. Is my plan still the right plan, or do I need to switch?
3. What's the one thing I can do right now to widen / close the gap?

Don't play on autopilot. The right move at 8 minutes is wrong at 16 minutes. Re-read the state regularly.

1. **Minimap first.** Read it before clicking anything.
2. **30-second survey** at game start. Don't skip.
3. **The map mirrors.** Predict the enemy's layout from your own.
4. **Three rings.** Inner = yours. Middle = contested. Outer = late-game.
5. **Identify the archetype.** Open / Choke / Island / Highland / Asymmetric.
6. **Let resources dictate strategy.** Don't force a plan onto the wrong map.
7. **Use terrain as free defense.** Cliffs, hills, water, forests, narrow passes.
8. **Read the state every 90s.** Ahead = press. Equal = open. Behind = stall.

END OF DOCUMENT

FIELD MANUAL // MAP READING // PRINTED FOR INTERNAL USE

BASE LAYOUT+BUILDINGS

EVERY BUILDING
HAS A SECOND
COST

WALKING TIME

BUILD WHERE IT
FIGHTS

USE THE TERRAIN

DOCTRINE

THREE LAWS OF LAYOUT

| READ FIRST

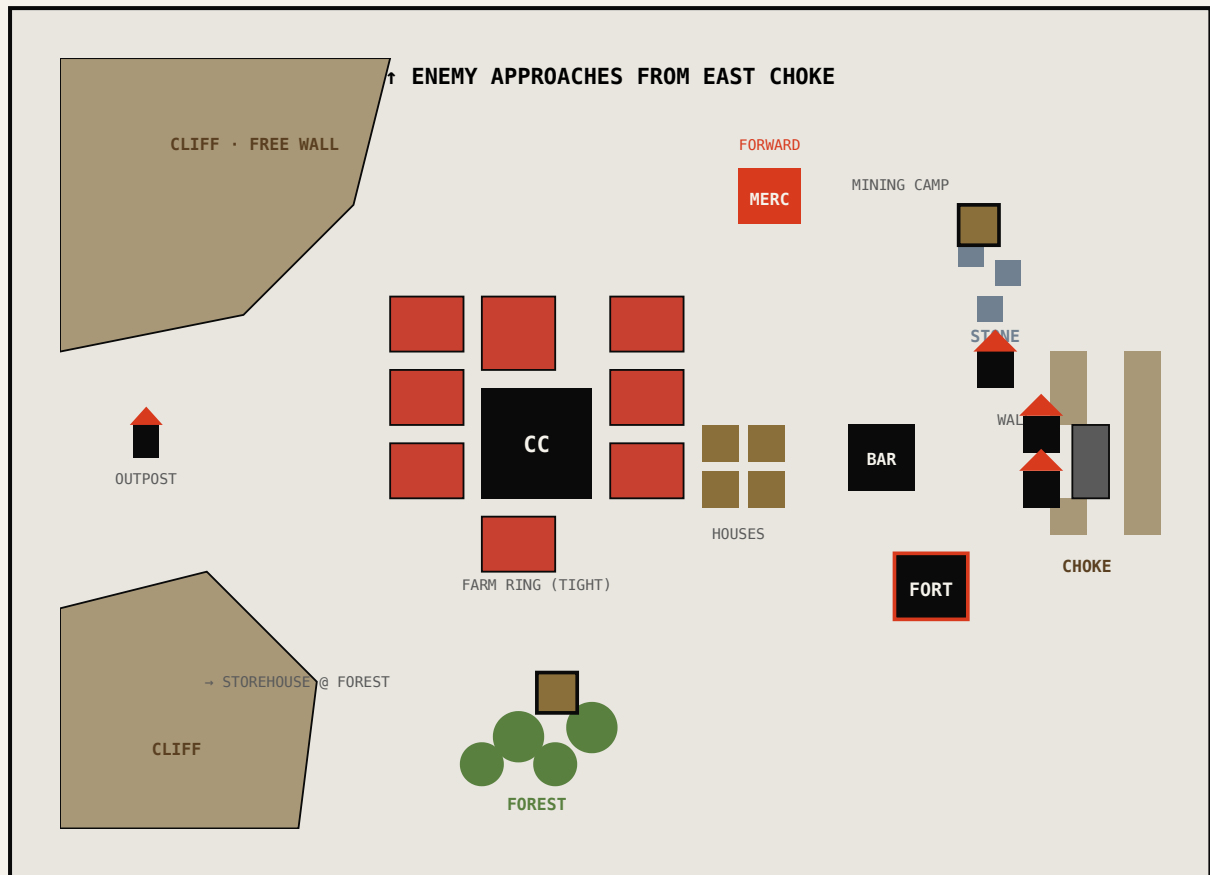
LAW 01 – Every building has TWO costs: the resources to build it, AND the **walking time** it adds to its users. The second cost is invisible but enormous.

LAW 02 – **Build where it fights.** Barracks near the front, towers at chokes, mercs near the action. Centralized = trickle reinforcements = lost battles.

LAW 03 – **Use the terrain.** The map already built half your defense – cliffs, water, forests, chokes. Just complete it.

BUILDING-BY- BUILDING RULES

BUILDING	WHERE TO PLACE	COMMON MISTAKE
Civic Centre	Near a food source (berries, sheep, water). Leave room for farms.	On a map edge or far from food
Farms	Clustered tightly around CC. 8-12 farms in a ring touching it.	Scattered far from CC
Storehouse	AT the edge of the forest, not 20 tiles away. One per resource cluster.	Far from the woodline (silent eco bleed)
Houses	Cluster near CC. Bonus: maze them near tower/choke for defense.	Wasted on perimeter
Barracks	Forward, not central. Between CC and the enemy choke. Rally → forward.	Deep in base, reinforcements arrive too late
Fortress	At the choke, behind 1-2 towers. Anchor of defense + champion + hero training.	Built late, only used reactively
Towers	Cover resource lines, chokes, gaps between CC and forward base. Overlap zones.	Around base perimeter instead of at chokes
Walls	ONLY at chokes. Use cliffs/forests/water for the rest.	Trying to wall the whole base (slow + wasteful)
Mercenary Camp	Halfway to enemy, near forward outpost. Reinforcements appear at the fight.	Built near home – defeats the purpose



// WHY THIS LAYOUT WORKS

- **Cliffs at the back** – free walls on two sides. Only one direction to defend.
- **Farms ring the CC** – minimum walking time for food.
- **Storehouse AT the forest** – 3 steps from chopping to dropping.
- **Barracks forward** – between CC and the choke. Reinforcements arrive quickly.
- **Fort + 2 towers + wall at the choke** – kill box. Every attacker funnels here.
- **Merc camp far forward** – pizza delivery at the front line.
- **Outpost on the safe side** – vision for raids that try to come around.

These buildings give massive value but most beginners skip them. Adding them properly is a top-5 way to improve your win rate.

**TEMPLE**

// HEALING & SUSTAINMENT

Trains **healers** who passively heal nearby units. In 0 A.D., wounded units don't auto-heal – they stay damaged forever. Build 1 temple, train 3–5 healers, park them behind your standing army. Your army recovers HP between fights for free.

**MARKET**

// TRADE ROUTES & BARTER

Build 2 **markets** – one home, one forward. **Trade carts** between them generate metal passively. Income equal to ~5–8 villagers, zero maintenance. Ptolemies have a trade bonus – even more efficient. Also lets you barter (food → metal in emergencies).

**WONDER**

// WIN CONDITION + BONUS

Massive Phase III building. Two functions: (1) passive civ bonus, (2) **Wonder Victory** – hold it for ~25 minutes, you auto-win. Use when ahead and want to close out, OR in a stalemate (forces opponent to attack). Only build if you can defend it.

**EMBASSY**

// FOREIGN MERCENARIES

Different from Ptolemies merc camp. Unlocks foreign units – Iberian skirmishers, Italic swordsmen, Celtic cavalry. Use to fill **composition gaps**. Iberian skirmishers especially are cheap and great. Pick one embassy; don't build all three.

**BLACKSMITH**

// UPGRADE ENGINE

Phase II, EARLY. Research weapon/armor +1 immediately, +2 mid-game, +3 late. Affects EVERY combat unit. Universal ROI. Not optional. (See VOL.05 for upgrade priority order.)

**STABLE**

// CAVALRY PRODUCTION

Place near your forward base, not your home. Cav is harass + flank – they should spawn where they fight. Stable-specific upgrades are only worth it if you have 8+ of that cav type.

// BUILD PRIORITY FOR SPECIAL BUILDINGS

01 Blacksmith – Phase II, early. Most important.

ALWAYS

02 Temple – Phase II, for healers. Massive sustainment.

ALWAYS

03

Market – Phase II, for trade income. Underused gold mine.

ALWAYS

04

Embassy – Phase II/III, if you need a foreign unit type.

CONDITIONAL

05

Wonder – Phase III, only if you can defend it.

CONDITIONAL

MAP RES

SPECIAL MAP RESOURCES

| FREE STUFF · GO GET IT

RESOURCE	WHAT IT IS	HOW TO USE
Treasure Chests	Randomly placed at game start. Give 100–300 of a random resource.	Send scout cav to grab them. Free resources, no work. Don't ignore.
Hunt (deer, gazelle)	Free roaming animals. Each gives 50–100 food.	Cav can hunt safely. Faster than berries early game.
Boar / Dangerous Hunt	100–200 food but bites back. Aggressive.	Lure with a tough unit, kill from range. Don't lose villagers to it.
Berries	Bushes near your CC. ~250 food per bush.	Your starting food source. Run dry around minute 6 – be on farms by then.
Fish (shore)	Schools of fish in water. Slow but bottomless food.	Build a dock, train fishing boats. Sustainable food forever.
Ruins / Special features	Map-specific. Some give bonuses when garrisoned.	Worth scouting for. Check each map's quirks.

// WHEN

Drop your second CC **when Phase II completes** ($\approx$ minute 8–10). You're ready when you have ~40 villagers and steady gathering.

// THE THREE CRITERIA FOR THE SPOT

1. **Resource cluster nearby** – stone + metal + some food/wood within 15s walk
2. **Defensible** – a choke, cliff, or natural barrier between it and the enemy
3. **Inside the middle ring** – not so far you can't defend it (the trickle trap!)

If you can't get all three: pick defensibility over resources. A second CC you can defend is worth more than a richer second CC that dies.

// BUILD ORDER AT THE NEW CC

1. Drop the CC
2. **IMMEDIATELY** build a tower next to it (within 30s walk)
3. Farms around the CC
4. Storehouse at the nearest forest
5. Barracks if you're going to fight here

New CC with no tower = villagers die to a single cav raid. Tower first. Eco second.

LAYOUT MISTAKES THAT BLEED

✗ **Storehouse 20+ tiles from the woodline.** Silent eco bleed every second.

✗ **Farms scattered around the map.** Women walking 15s when they should walk 2s.

✗ **Barracks deep in your base.** Reinforcements arrive too late to matter.

✗ **Towers at the base perimeter** instead of the choke. Same number of enemies shot, but no crossfire.

✗ **Walling your whole base.** Wasteful, slow, and your own units can't get out efficiently.

✗ **Forgetting to build storehouses at all.** Gather rate halves as the deposit is depleted nearby.

✗ **No Blacksmith / Temple / Market.** All three give huge ROI. Skipping them = playing handicapped.

✗ **Mercenary camp at home base.** Defeats the entire purpose. Push it forward.

1. **Every building has a walking-time cost.** Place where it's used.
2. **Farms ring the CC.** Storehouses kiss the forest.
3. **Barracks forward. Merc camp further forward.**
4. **Walls only at chokes. Use terrain for the rest.**
5. **Towers at chokes, not perimeter.** Overlapping fire.
6. **Build Blacksmith, Temple, Market** by Phase II. Every game.
7. **Grab treasure chests early.** Free resources, no excuse.
8. **Second CC: defensible > rich.** Tower before farms.

END OF DOCUMENT

FIELD MANUAL // BASE LAYOUT + BUILDINGS // PRINTED FOR INTERNAL USE